



TROOPS SURROUND
A PROTESTER IN
XINJIANG PROVINCE

AFP PHOTO

SUPPRESS INTERNAL DISSENT AND ALSO GET ASSERTIVE WITH INDIA.

bad news and are the first to report on disasters.”

A recent report in another national daily from its reporter at Mushan city in Sichuan talked of the new guidelines against corruption issued by the provincial government for its bureaucrats, especially during after office hours. According to the guideline: “Officials should persist in being upright and honest after work hours, should not have too close relations with people that are interest related and should not have abnormal relations with the opposite sex.” The reason: A majority of the officials are corrupt and even have mistresses. One general manager, who admitted to having 13 mistresses, said he considered it an exhibition of official power.

Even as it loosens its grip over the media, state control is evident and inconvenient websites or blogs are blacked out and newspapers and dailies are warned not to cross the invisible red lines laid down by officials. The Chinese Government’s continuing inability to deal with debate and dissent is a sign of its weaknesses and the heavy hand with which it comes down on those who disagree with it is symbolic of its sense of vulnerability, despite its phenomenal ascendancy on the world stage.

Of late, though, there has been a rising sense of nationalism and xenophobia that comes with China understanding its importance, especially that of its explosive economic growth, to the world. The Government is intolerant of anyone who questions China’s growth. Young people post-Tiananmen are fed with a continuous diet of how great China is and also that the goal of regaining China’s lost status is the sacred mission of its 1.2 billion-strong population. Yet senior Chinese officials

take pains to point out that China historically has never been hegemonistic and one of them says, “China’s development is not a threat but an opportunity for the world.”

So what do all these changes in China mean for India? Already the rising nationalism has resulted in China being assertive with not just India over the border dispute but in its maritime and land boundary issues with Vietnam, Japan and the Philippines. Officials though see its toughening stand over Arunachal Pradesh as a negotiating tactic to delay a settlement on the boundary issue despite 13 rounds of talks, with the last one being held recently. With Tibet still a burning issue and the Dalai Lama ensconced in Dharamsala there is a sense that China wants to continue to use the border dispute as a lever to regulate India’s ability to play up this sensitive issue. Experts point out that more than a territorial settlement, the border issue needs a political solution between the two.

Indian diplomats look at the current state of relations with China as “work in progress”. In the past few years the road has got wider with bilateral trade improving significantly and relations acquiring more substance and an element of stability. But China is benchmarking its progress more with the US, Japan and Europe than India. The average Chinese image of India is what the movie *Slumdog Millionaire* portrayed—a surreal montage of slums, cows, crowds, colour and culture. They usually find India chaotic instead of the Confucian cohesiveness they seek. The new China seems to like to play a game of patience while dealing with India. If India loses its patience, it may well lose the game. ■